

Isaac Brito-Morales, Ph.D.

Senior Associate Scientist • Research Associate

Conservation International, Arlington, United States

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Work and Research

Senior Associate Scientist

Conservation International, Moore Center for Science

Arlington, United States

Jul 2024 – Present

Associate Research Scientist

Conservation International, Moore Center for Science

Arlington, United States

2021 – Jun 2024

Research Associate

University of California, Santa Barbara, Marine Science Institute

Santa Barbara, United States

Nov 2024 – Present

Affiliated Researcher

University of California, Santa Barbara, Marine Science Institute

Santa Barbara, United States

2022 – Oct 2024

Postdoctoral Research Fellow

University of Queensland, School of Mathematics and Physics

Brisbane, Australia

Feb 2021 – Sep 2021

Project Manager

Centro de Ecología Aplicada

Chile

2010 – 2016

Lecturer in Experimental Design

Universidad Católica de la Santísima Concepción

Concepción, Chile

2008 – 2009

Education

Ph.D. Biological Sciences

University of Queensland

Brisbane, Australia

2016 – 2021

B.Sc. 1st Class Hons, Marine Biology

Universidad Católica de la Santísima Concepción

Concepción, Chile

2003 – 2008

Awards and Honors

Academic Excellence

Science Faculty, Universidad Católica de la Santísima Concepción

Concepción, Chile

2008

Grants and Fellowships

Save the Blue Five – IKI Project

International Climate Initiative, BMUV/Germany; co-lead on climate change vulnerability and conservation planning for highly migratory megafauna

International

2023 – Present

Belmont Forum / Ocean Front Change Project

Contributor to international project on climate and dynamic ocean features

International

2021 – 2024

Ph.D. Grant

Chilean National Research and Development Agency (ANID)

Chile

2016

Peer-Reviewed Publications

In Press and Published

Sanz-Martín M, Olguin-Jacobson C, Bolin JA, Quiles-Pons C, **Brito-Morales I**, García Molinos J, Hidalgo M, Alabía ID, Gissi E, Provost MM, Micheli F, Arafeh-Dalmau N. 2026. Identifying marine climate refugia to advance climate-smart conservation. *Trends in Ecology & Evolution*. In press. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tree.2026.04.007>.

Buenafe KCV, Dunn DC, Metaxas A, Schoeman DS, Everett JD, Pidd A, Hanson JO, Bentley LK, Kim SW, Neubert S, Scales KL, Dabalà A, **Brito-Morales I**, Richardson AJ. 2025. Current approaches and future opportunities for climate-smart protected areas. *Nature Reviews Biodiversity*. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1038/s44358-025-00041-0>.

Hannah L, Irvine A, **Brito-Morales I**, Fuller S, Davies T, Tittensor D, Reville G, Shackell N, Hennicke J, Stanley R. 2024. To save the high seas, plan for climate change. *Nature*. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1038/d41586-024-01720-2>.

Sanz-Martín M, Hidalgo M, Puerta P, García Molinos J, Zamanillo M, **Brito-Morales I**, González-Irusta JM, Esteban A, Punzón A, García-Rodríguez E, Vivas M, López-López L. 2024. Climate velocity drives unexpected southward patterns of species shifts in the Western Mediterranean Sea. *Ecological Indicators*. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ecolind.2024.111741>.

Schoeman DS, Sen Gupta A, Harrison CS, Everett J, **Brito-Morales I**, Hannah L, Bopp L, Roehrdanz P, Richardson AJ. 2023. Demystifying global climate models for use in the life sciences. *Trends in Ecology & Evolution*. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tree.2023.04.005>.

Buenafe KCV, Dunn D, Everett J, **Brito-Morales I**, Schoeman DS, Hanson JO, Dabalà A, Neubert S, Cannicci S, Kaschner K, Richardson AJ. 2023. A metric-based framework for climate-smart conservation planning. *Ecological Applications*. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1002/eap.2852>.

Brito-Morales I, Schoeman DS, Everett J, Klein CJ, Dunn D, García Molinos J, Burrows MT, Buenafe KCV, Dominguez RM, Possingham HP, Richardson AJ. 2022. Towards climate-smart, three-dimensional protected areas for biodiversity conservation in the high seas. *Nature Climate Change* 12, 402–407. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41558-022-01323-7>.

Arafeh-Dalmau N, **Brito-Morales I**, Schoeman DS, Possingham HP, Klein CJ, Richardson AJ. 2021. Incorporating climate velocity into the design of climate-smart networks of marine protected areas. *Methods in Ecology and Evolution*. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1111/2041-210X.13675>.

Brito-Morales I, Schoeman DS, García Molinos J, Burrows MT, Klein CJ, Arafeh-Dalmau N, Kaschner K, Garilao C, Kesner-Reyes K, Richardson AJ. 2020. Climate velocity reveals increasing exposure of deep-ocean biodiversity to future warming. *Nature Climate Change* 10, 576–581. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41558-020-0773-5>.

Brito-Morales I, García Molinos J, Schoeman DS, Burrows MT, Poloczanska ES, Brown CJ, Ferrier S, Harwood TD, Klein CJ, McDonald-Madden E, Moore PJ, Pandolfi JM, Watson JEM, Wenger AS, Richardson AJ. 2018. Climate velocity can inform conservation in a warming world. *Trends in Ecology & Evolution* 33, 441–457. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tree.2018.03.009>.

In Preparation, Review or Revision (drafts available upon request)

Isaac Brito-Morales, Nur Arafeh-Dalmau, Yulia Egorova, Guillermo Ortuno Crespo, Lee Hannah. Static tools in a dynamic ocean: why marine protection must evolve to survive climate change. *In review*.

Ian Omedes Bassat, Manuel Hidalgo, Carla Quiles-Pons, Jorge García Molinos, **Isaac Brito-Morales**, Nur Arafeh-Dalmau, Javier Soto-Navarro, Marina Sanz-Martín. Multifaceted thermal exposure reveals climate refugia shortfalls in the Mediterranean marine protected areas. *In review*.

Isaac Brito-Morales, Boris Dewitte, Floriane Sudre, Christoph A. Rohner, Elliott L. Hazen, Kylie L. Scales, Matthieu Le Corre, Audrey Jaeger, Sophie Laran, Olivier Bousquet, Ana M. M. Sequeira, Tammy E. Davies, Daniel C. Dunn, Ronel Nel, Lee Hannah, Vincent Rossi. Megafauna show pervasive yet distinct affinity to ocean fronts: the urgent need for adaptive conservation in a warming world. *Communications Biology*. In review. Preprint DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1101/2025.06.17.660201>

Teaching

Instruction

Instructor

UCSB, ESM240 Climate Change Biology (graduate course)

Santa Barbara, United States

2023, 2025

- Designed and delivered graduate-level lectures, developed assignments, supervised projects, and evaluated coursework.

Teaching Assistant

University of Queensland, Advanced Analysis of Scientific Data

Brisbane, Australia

2019 – 2020

Teaching Assistant

University of Queensland, Analysis of Scientific Data

Brisbane, Australia

2019 – 2020

Teaching Assistant

University of Queensland, Pharmacy – Data Analysis & Professional Practice

Brisbane, Australia

2019 – 2020

Teaching Assistant

University of Queensland, Probability & Statistics in Engineering

Brisbane, Australia

2019

Teaching Assistant

University of Queensland, Environmental Data Analysis

Brisbane, Australia

2018

Teaching Assistant

University of Queensland, Biostatistics & Experimental Design

Brisbane, Australia

2018

Academic Service & Leadership

Organizer

CERFACS, Climate and Ocean Modeling Workshop: Applications of Regional Ocean Models for Marine Megafauna Conservation in the Southeast Pacific

Toulouse, France

2025

Organizer

Conservation International, Climate Change and Marine Megafauna Workshop

David, Panama

2025

Invited Workshop Contributor

Acadia University, Ocean Front, Megafauna and Climate Change

Wolfville, Canada

2024

Invited Workshop Contributor

Nelson Mandela University, Ocean Front and Climate Change

Gqeberha, South Africa

2023

Conference Presentations

Invited

Cambio climático en el océano: la dimensión ignorada en conservación

Encuentro del Pacífico Sudeste

Ciudad de Panamá, Panamá

2024

Climate velocity in the ocean and its implications for conservation

Palma de Mallorca, Spain

Contributed

Ocean Front Change, Belmont Forum Session: Oceans 2018 End-term

Helsinki, Finland

Sustainability, Research & Innovation Congress

2024

Managing dynamic ocean front ecosystems for species on the move

Bonita Springs, United States

Species on the Move

2023

Climate velocity in the ocean and its implications for conservation

Vancouver, Canada

IMPAC5

2023

Challenges and opportunities for managing ocean front ecosystems in a warming world

Online

Ocean Sciences Meeting

2022

Life below the ocean surface increasingly threatened by climate change

Kruger National Park, South Africa

Species on the Move

2019

Mentoring

Sarayu Ramnath & Lenaya-Aiden Gonzales

Santa Barbara, United States

Bren School, UCSB; Save the Blue Five – IKI climate change assessment and conservation planning for highly migratory species

2025 – Present

Sarayu Ramnath & Lenaya-Aiden Gonzales

Santa Barbara, United States

Bren School, UCSB; climate change assessment and the role of ocean fronts in structuring megafauna–fisheries interactions

2025 – Present

Kristine Camille Buenafe

International

Mundus Masters Degree in Tropical Biodiversity and Ecosystems; benefits and costs to pelagic fisheries of conservation-sensitive, climate-smart closures in the Pacific Ocean

2021

Rosa Mar Dominguez

International

Mundus Masters Degree in Tropical Biodiversity and Ecosystems; conservation of the high seas: designing climate-smart reserves in the Indian Ocean

2020

Rafaela de Albuquerque Ribeiro

International

Mundus Masters Degree in Tropical Biodiversity and Ecosystems; designing climate-proof marine protected areas: a case study in South America

2019

References

Prof Anthony Richardson (anthony.richardson@csiro.au)

Prof David Schoeman (dschoema@usc.edu.au)

A/Prof Jorge Garcia Molinos (garciamj@tcd.ie)

Languages Spoken

Fluent Spanish; Fluent English